

## THIRTY TERMS · PLAIN ENGLISH · ZERO HYPE

# AI vocabulary for teachers

Every AI term you'll actually hear this year — in staff meetings, headlines, and from your students — explained the way you'd explain it to a colleague in the hallway.

## The basics

|                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>AI (artificial intelligence)</b> | Software that does tasks we used to think required human thinking: writing, summarizing, answering questions. Umbrella term; most of what people mean right now is the next entry. |
| <b>Generative AI</b>                | AI that <b>creates new content</b> — text, images, audio — instead of just sorting or finding things. ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, and Copilot are all generative AI.                  |
| <b>Chatbot</b>                      | The chat-window way of talking to an AI. You type, it replies, the conversation continues with memory of what was said earlier in that chat.                                       |
| <b>LLM (large language model)</b>   | The engine under the chatbot: a model trained on enormous amounts of text to predict what words come next. "Model" and "LLM" get used interchangeably.                             |
| <b>Prompt</b>                       | Whatever you type into the AI. The single biggest factor in whether you get something useful. <b>Better prompt, better draft — every time.</b>                                     |
| <b>Output / response</b>            | What the AI gives back. Treat every output as a first draft from an eager intern: often good, never final, always yours to review.                                                 |
| <b>Iterating</b>                    | Replying to the AI to improve its draft — "shorter," "warmer," "make it a table" — instead of starting over. Where most of the real value is.                                      |

## How it works (the honest version)

|                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Training data</b>    | The text the model learned from — much of the public internet, books, and licensed sources. Why it knows so much, and why it inherits the internet's mistakes.                                          |
| <b>Hallucination</b>    | When AI states something false with total confidence: invented citations, wrong dates, fake quotes. <b>Not a rare glitch — a built-in behavior.</b> Verify anything factual before it reaches students. |
| <b>Bias</b>             | Patterns from the training data showing up in outputs — assumptions about names, cultures, genders, abilities. Another reason your professional read-through is non-negotiable.                         |
| <b>Context window</b>   | How much the AI can "hold in mind" in one conversation. Long chats eventually push early details out; if it gets forgetful, start fresh.                                                                |
| <b>Token</b>            | The word-chunks AI actually reads and writes (roughly $\frac{3}{4}$ of a word each). Mostly matters when a tool talks about limits or pricing.                                                          |
| <b>Machine learning</b> | The broader technique of teaching software from examples instead of writing rules by hand. AI's parent category; fine to use the terms loosely.                                                         |
| <b>Algorithm</b>        | Any step-by-step procedure a computer follows. The word sounds precise but is used for everything; on its own it tells you almost nothing.                                                              |
| <b>GPT</b>              | "Generative pre-trained transformer" — the architecture behind many models and the reason ChatGPT is named that. You never need the long version.                                                       |
| <b>Multimodal</b>       | A model that handles more than text: reads images, hears audio, describes photos. Why students can now snap a picture of a worksheet and ask for answers.                                               |

## The school-safety words

|                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>PII</b>                       | Personally identifiable information — anything that could identify a specific student: name, ID, photo, or a unique combination of details. <b>The one hard rule: student PII never goes into a public AI tool.</b> |
| <b>FERPA</b>                     | The federal law protecting student education records. Typing student information into a consumer chatbot can put you on the wrong side of it — de-identify instead.                                                 |
| <b>COPPA</b>                     | The federal law behind most "13 and up" age limits on consumer AI tools. Why students under 13 shouldn't have accounts on public chatbots.                                                                          |
| <b>De-identification</b>         | Rewriting a prompt so no one could tell which child it's about: strip the identity, generalize, describe the need — "a 7th grader reading below grade level," never a name.                                         |
| <b>Public AI tool</b>            | A consumer chatbot with no contract with your district (free ChatGPT, Gemini, etc.). Fine for adult planning with no student data; not a place for anything about a specific child.                                 |
| <b>District-approved tool</b>    | An AI product your district has vetted and signed a data-privacy agreement with. The difference isn't the AI — it's the contract about where data goes.                                                             |
| <b>AI detector</b>               | Software claiming to spot AI-written work. <b>Unreliable enough that major providers pulled theirs</b> — false accusations are common. Better evidence: your knowledge of the student's writing, and process work.  |
| <b>Academic integrity policy</b> | Your school's rules on what AI help is allowed on student work. If yours doesn't mention AI yet, clear expectations from you, stated per-assignment, fill the gap.                                                  |

## Buzzwords, decoded

|                           |                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Prompt engineering</b> | A grand name for a simple skill: writing clear, specific requests. If you can write good sub plans, you can do this.                                                  |
| <b>AI literacy</b>        | Knowing what AI can and can't do, when to trust it, and how to use it responsibly. What this page is. Increasingly named in state guidance.                           |
| <b>AI agent</b>           | AI that takes multi-step actions on its own (browsing, booking, filing) instead of just chatting. Coming to school software; worth knowing the word.                  |
| <b>Open source model</b>  | A model whose underlying weights anyone can download and run. Matters for tech departments; for classrooms it changes little.                                         |
| <b>Fine-tuning</b>        | Extra training that specializes a model for one job — how companies build "AI tutors" from general models. Marketing loves this word.                                 |
| <b>Wrapper</b>            | A product that is mostly a familiar AI model with a new interface on top — many "AI for education" tools. Ask what the tool adds beyond the chatbot you already have. |

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